

2.1 Prose: narrative methods

Paper 2 Prose and Unseen · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Narrative perspective controls what readers can know. Focalisation is whose perceptions shape a scene; an unreliable narrator may misread or withhold. Time shifts, dialogue and free indirect style affect sympathy. Link a short passage to wider patterns in the prescribed novel where the question requires whole-text knowledge.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

“She called it a small mistake, although the village still counted the missing boats” puts the character's minimising phrase beside communal consequence, inviting doubt.

Original practice stimulus

Jonah said the house was empty. He said it while looking at the kitchen floor and again when Mira asked why the upstairs light was on. He did not offer to check. In the entrance hall he pointed out a damp mark on the wall, explaining that the roof had leaked for years, but he walked past the staircase without turning his head. Mira noticed a pair of shoes beneath the first step. They were clean, though dust covered the boards around them. “The caretaker comes sometimes,” Jonah said before she asked. Outside, the window showed a pale square of light. When Mira returned to the road, she could no longer see it.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original extract: “Jonah said the house was empty. He avoided the upstairs light [25]
and left its switch untouched.” Explain how viewpoint and detail shape trust in Jonah.

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong response explores “said” as unverified report, avoidance and untouched switch as suggestive gaps, and resists claiming the light proves a ghost or crime. Structure paragraphs around reader knowledge and withheld information.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

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<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.